

birth partner quick guide

The Big Picture

Position changes can help baby rotate, descend, and align

Think movement + asymmetry (one knee up, one down)

Back pain often means baby needs help turning, not just pushing harder

Change position before assuming something is wrong

Early Labour / Labour Slow to Start

If contractions are irregular or fading: Stay upright: walking, swaying, leaning forward

Try Forward-Leaning Inversion (with support)

Use Side-Lying Release (both sides)

Avoid lying flat on the back

Partner role: Offer steady support

Time positions (10 minutes or 3 contractions)

Reassure: "We're helping baby find space."



Active Labour / Labour Stalls

- If contractions weaken or space out: Change position every 20–40 minutes

Try:

- Lunges (opens mid-pelvis)
- Hands and knees Leaning over a bed, chair, or ball

If baby may need help rotating:

- Shake the Apple Tree (gentle hip jiggling)
- Sifting with a scarf or rebozo
- Use asymmetry: one knee open, one closed



Knees: When to Open vs When to Narrow

Open Knees = More Space (Descent)

Use when:

- Baby feels high
- Pressure without progress
- Before pushing

Good positions:

- Supported squat
- Toilet sitting
- Birth stool
- All fours with wide knees
- Birth ball open knees

Narrow or Asymmetrical Knees = Rotation

Use when:

- Strong back pain
- Baby feels stuck
- Labour slows despite strong contractions

Good positions:

- Side-lying with top leg supported
- Hands and knees (knees under hips)
- Lunges

birth partner quick guide

Back Labour & Intense Pelvic Pressure

Use Counter Pressure

When:

- Pain is in the lower back
- Birthing person asks for pressure
- Contractions feel overwhelming

Options:

- Sacral pressure (flat palm on sacrum whenever needed)
- Hip squeeze (during contractions)

Partner tips:

- Use body weight, not just hands
- Pressure should be firm and steady
- Stop if it increases pain



Pushing Stage

If pushing feels ineffective:

Change position:

- Side-lying
- All fours
- One leg up/one leg down
- Avoid long periods on the back

Partner role:

- Support legs or hips
- Help maintain balance
- Encourage rest between pushes

Partner Quick Check

- Have we changed position recently?
- Are we upright or forward-leaning?
- Do we need more space or more rotation?
- Would gentle pressure help right now?
- Have they been to the toilet recently?
- Do they need hydrating or fuel?



You don't need to fix birth, just help create space, comfort, and confidence

Leanne xx

